

# The NCERT Booklist, Prioritized

The exact NCERTs to read, and the order to read them in, for every GS subject — so you stop guessing where to start.

**How to use this:** Read Tier 1 books first, cover to cover, before touching any standard reference book (Laxmikanth, Spectrum, GC Leong, etc.). Tier 2 books fill gaps once your foundation is solid. Don't collect more books than this — revising these three times beats reading forty books once.

## History

| TIER          | CLASS | BOOK                                    | WHY IT MATTERS                                                         |
|---------------|-------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VI    | Our Pasts I                             | Ancient India — foundational timeline and sources                      |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VII   | Our Pasts II                            | Medieval India — Delhi Sultanate to Mughals                            |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VIII  | Our Pasts III (Part 1 & 2)              | Colonial India, 1857, socio-religious reform                           |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | IX    | India and the Contemporary World I      | World History — French Revolution, Nazism                              |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | X     | India and the Contemporary World II     | Nationalism in India & the world                                       |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | Themes in World History                 | World History depth for GS I Mains                                     |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII   | Themes in Indian History I, II, III     | The single most important History NCERT set for UPSC — read this twice |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Old NCERT: Ancient India (R.S. Sharma)  | Deeper ancient history than the new NCERT covers                       |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Old NCERT: Modern India (Bipan Chandra) | The standard for Modern History & freedom struggle depth               |

## Geography

| TIER          | CLASS | BOOK                                                | WHY IT MATTERS                                                     |
|---------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VI    | The Earth Our Habitat                               | Absolute basics — solar system, latitude/longitude                 |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VII   | Our Environment                                     | Landforms, climate, natural vegetation                             |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VIII  | Resources and Development                           | Resources, agriculture, industry — India-focused                   |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | Fundamentals of Physical Geography                  | The backbone of Prelims Geography — read carefully                 |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | India: Physical Environment                         | Physical geography of India specifically                           |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII   | Fundamentals of Human Geography                     | Human geography concepts tested almost every year                  |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII   | India: People and Economy                           | Population, settlements, economic activities of India              |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Certificate Physical & Human Geography (G.C. Leong) | Standard reference once NCERTs are done — go here next, not before |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Orient BlackSwan / Oxford School Atlas              | Keep open beside every geography topic you study                   |

## Polity

| TIER          | CLASS | BOOK                                 | WHY IT MATTERS                                                                |
|---------------|-------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | IX    | Democratic Politics I                | What democracy actually means, in plain language                              |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | X     | Democratic Politics II               | Federalism, political parties, social movements                               |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | Indian Constitution at Work          | The single best introduction to how the Constitution actually functions       |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | Political Theory                     | Rights, justice, equality — concepts GS II and Essay both draw on             |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII   | Politics in India Since Independence | Post-1947 political history — frequently tested                               |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Indian Polity (M. Laxmikanth)        | The standard reference — but only after the NCERTs above, not instead of them |

## Economy

| TIER          | CLASS | BOOK                                           | WHY IT MATTERS                                                |
|---------------|-------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | IX    | Economics (Understanding Economic Development) | Basic concepts — poverty, food security, development          |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | X     | Understanding Economic Development             | Sectors of the economy, money & credit, globalisation         |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XI    | Indian Economic Development                    | Read this closely — directly maps to GS III Economy questions |

|               |     |                               |                                                                                 |
|---------------|-----|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII | Introductory Macroeconomics   | National income, money, government budget — conceptual base for Economic Survey |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —   | Indian Economy (Ramesh Singh) | Standard reference for depth once NCERT concepts are clear                      |

Science, Environment & Culture

| TIER          | CLASS | BOOK                                     | WHY IT MATTERS                                                                     |
|---------------|-------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1</b> | VI–X  | Science (all five books)                 | Base concepts in physics, chemistry, biology that GS III questions assume you know |
| <b>Tier 1</b> | XII   | Biology — Ecology & Environment chapters | The most exam-relevant environment content in any NCERT                            |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | XI    | An Introduction to Indian Art            | Covers Art & Culture — a small but easy-marks section                              |
| <b>Tier 2</b> | —     | Nitin Singhania — Indian Art & Culture   | Standard reference for Art & Culture depth                                         |